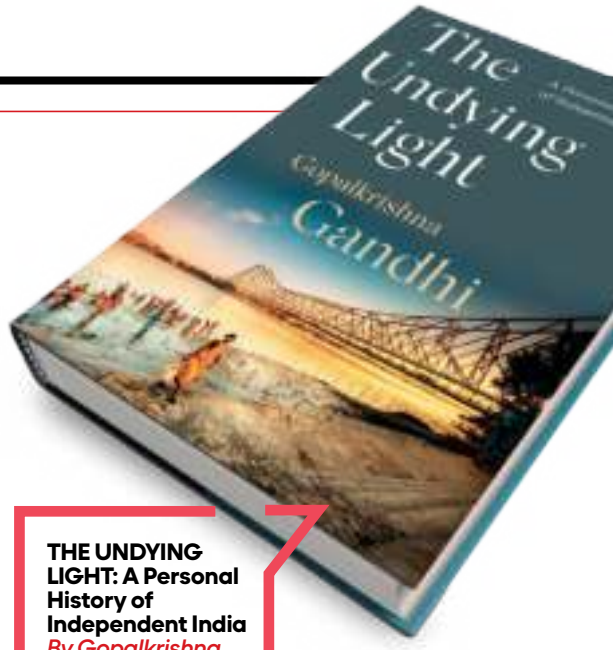


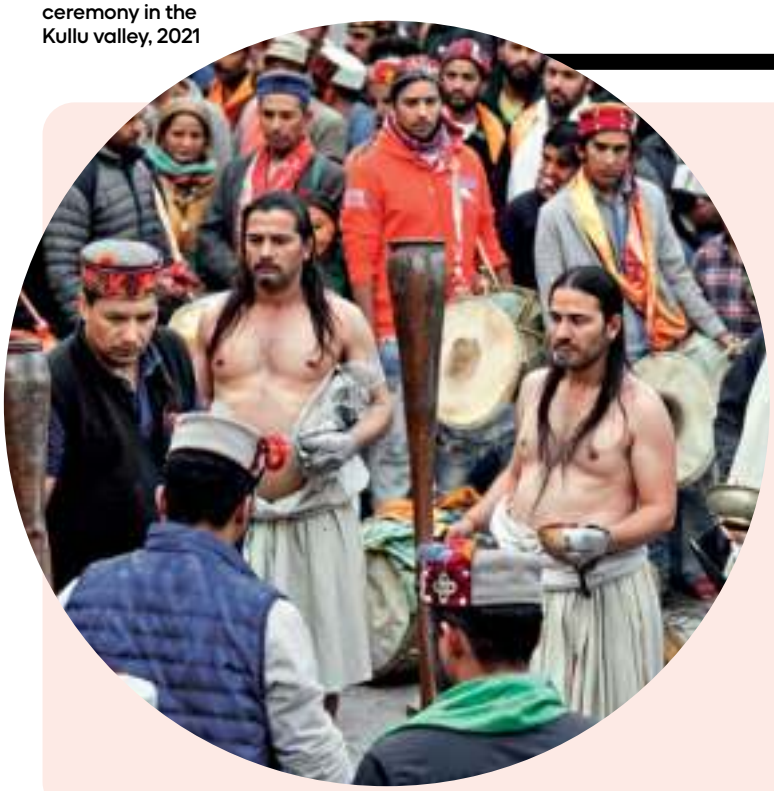
THE UNDYING LIGHT: A Personal History of Independent India
By Gopalkrishna Gandhi
ALEPH
₹999; 624 pages

Gopalkrishna Gandhi has led a varied and storied life—as a civil servant in India, as a diplomat abroad and as the grandson of both Mahatma Gandhi and C. Rajagopalachari. Three years ago, David Davidar of Aleph approached him with the idea of writing a personal history of post-independence India. "I was nobody to write about India or my fellow Indians," he mulls in his introduction. "But I could think of questions that had been with me over the years, defying answers."

Those questions, experiences and memories have now come together in *The Undying Light: A Personal History of Independent India*. This sweeping account is an easy, breezy read, and rarely flags despite being around 600 pages long. In an email interview, Gandhi, 80, says a "straightforward memoir" would have been "a tedious impudence".

"But a recollection of events outside or beside my own lived memories, supported by archival material and contemporary records, is a different thing," he says. "This is where the genre called 'a personal history', which is neither autobiographical nor historical, was worth turning to. A boring guy like me can have some not-so-boring memories of life as it shaped itself outside his own."

Gandhi was born in 1945, the youngest of four children to a Tamil mother and a Gujarati father. He studied in Delhi and then joined the IAS in 1968, with his first posting in Tamil Nadu. He later served as secretary to presidents R. Venkataraman and K.R. Narayanan, and as high commissioner in Sri Lanka and South Africa. Working in government brought its share of challenges: whether in serving different masters or sometimes being unable to prevent wrongdoing.



WITH THE SPIRITS Goors, Himalayan shamans, conduct a sacred ceremony in the Kullu valley, 2021

Where Gods Speak

AN INTREPID FILMMAKER DECODES
A LIVING SHAMANIC TRADITION

Anu Malhotra's *Shamans of the Himalayas* is a captivating blend of cultural inquiry and personal pilgrimage. Set in the enchanted valley of Kullu-Manali, this book, born out of her eponymous documentary series filmed from 2008 to 2010, is a compelling documentation of a living shamanic tradition that defies easy categorisation. At once an anthropological study and a spiritual travelogue, Malhotra transports readers into a world where gods speak through human mediums, nature is alive with divinity, and healing is both ritual and revelation.

The book unfolds in carefully structured the-